

1993: Plug And Play And Pentium

March: PnP Introduced

Microsoft introduced the Plug and Play initiative. This refers to the ease with which new components (Plug-and-Play-compatible) could be added to a system. For Plug and Play to be successfully implemented, three components have to interact—the device that is plugged in, the BIOS of the system into which it is plugged, and the operating system.

Any new device connected to a PC would report its specifications to the system BIOS allowing for allocation of resources (like Interrupts), and searching and installation of appropriate drivers by the operating system without requiring user intervention. Compaq Computer, Intel, and Phoenix Technologies were the initial supporters.

March: The Beginning Of The Pentium Era

Intel released the 3.1-million-transistor Pentium processor. Architecturally, the Pentium doubled the width of the data path compared to the i486, from the memory to the processor, to 64 bits, and could complete 2 instructions per clock cycle. Vinod Dham was the lead designer of the team behind the Pentium, and the title of Father of the Pentium is usually attributed to him.

April: First GUI Browser Takes Internet By Storm

Marc Andreessen and Eric Bina created the Mosaic Web browser, the first graphical browser, at the National Center for Supercomputing Applications, University of Illinois. It was originally created for the UNIX platform; Apple and Windows versions came by the end of the year. Before graphical browsers came into the picture (no pun intended), text browsers were the only way to surf the Net, and these were unable to open images embedded in the text. The popularity of the WWW exploded after the arrival of Mosaic. The Mosaic code was licensed to other browser manufacturers, including Microsoft, who used it to build their Internet Explorer.